5. Impact of the Religious/ Bhakti Movement

- Vedic Hinduism was regenerated and thus saved from the onslaught of Islam.
- The Islamic tenets – unity of God and universal brotherhood – emphasised by the saints promoted harmony and peace.
- Bhakti was a movement of the common people; it used the language of the common people for its devotional literature.
- Bhakti movement opened up space for Indian languages to grow. It stimulated literary activity in regional languages.
- What sustained Sanskrit, despite its decline during this period, was the support extended by the rulers of Hindu kingdoms.
- Tamil was the only ancient Indian language remained vibrant during this period. But the ethos of Tamil literature in medieval time had changed. In the classical period, it had secular literature depicting the everyday life, its joys and sorrows, but under the influence of devotional cults, its emphasis shifted to religion and religious literature.
- Caste system and social disparities came to be criticised.

Summary

❖ The Bhakti movement is explained. Azhwars' initiatives followed by Nayanmars in Tamil country are described.

❖ Adi Shankarar's *advaita* philosophy and Ramanujar's *vishistadvaita* philosophy are explained.

❖ The devotional paths of saints, notably Tulsidas and Meera Bai, in northern India and Chaitanyadeva in Bengal are examined.

❖ Mutual influence of Islam and Hinduism and birth of Sufism, Sikhism and mystical Hinduism are discussed in brief.

❖ Radical versions of Bhakti Movement: Contribution of Kabir and Guru Nanak are detailed.

❖ The essential features of Bhakti Movement are highlighted.

❖ The impact of the Bhakti Movement on the medieval Indian society is analysed.

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